

Monday, May 18		
6:00pm-7:00pm	Nelson (from F Block)	Fawwaz (from F Block)
	KJ (from E Block)	Eva (from E Block)
	Anar (from E Block)	Emilie (F Block)

Nelson:

The forming of both PACT in *Our Missing Hearts* and the Red/Lavender Scares were as a result of a fear of foreign influence. To pass PACT, some pinned the blame on China, stating, “all manipulations, their tariffs and devaluations. Maybe they’d even had help, dismantling us from within” (179). Likewise, the Red and Lavender Scares were formed from a fear of Soviet influence, with McKinley stating in “Senator Joseph McCarthy Describes the Internal Communist Menace,” “The reason why we find ourselves in a position of impotency is not because our only powerful potential enemy has sent men to invade our shores, but rather because of the traitorous actions of those who have been treated so well by this Nation” (MP 296).

However, PACT’s consequences were much more severe compared to the Red and Lavender Scares, where the government was “quietly removing children from un-American environments” (185) and society was quiet. What were differences in the events leading up to these two events and/or the responses to these two events that caused such a large difference in consequences from PACT and the Red and Lavender scares?

KJ:

Throughout *Our Missing Hearts*, Celeste Ng depicts ordinary people who publicly renounce those they love, comply with surveillance, and intentionally remain blind to suffering so long as it isn’t their own. To exemplify, when Bird’s father is confronted by police officers at their front door, “That woman is no longer part of this family, he said brusquely. We have nothing to do with her. We have had nothing to do with her since she left. It was as if his father had struck his mother, right there in front of him. And we have absolutely no sympathies for the radical stances she supported, his father went on. Absolutely none. He gave Bird a look, and Bird stiffened his spine into an iron bar and nodded” (Ng 41¹). This quote echoes with the ideologies of the Second Red Scare, from roughly 1947-1954, when citizens were required to sign loyalty oaths and people disavowed friends and colleagues to protect themselves. Additionally, the Department of Justice had a “China Initiative” that targeted Chinese-Americans—particularly scientists—through dubious investigations, and according to the Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS), “Under the China Initiative, a majority of US-based scientists of Chinese descent now feel the chilling effect of potential federal investigations and prosecution and have a new reason to be pessimistic about their careers in the US.” Ng’s novel asserts the idea that systems of racial targeting like PACT are not only upheld by those in power but also by those in compliance. Considering how fear demonstrates control and influence over people

¹ E-book page number, as I am without my paper copy of *Our Missing Hearts*

based on the results of the PNAS study, and the ideologies characteristic of the Second Red Scare, to what extent should Bird's father be held morally accountable for his behavior? How does the author intend us to perceive, judge, or understand the actions of Bird's father?

Anar:

On page 82 of "Our Missing Hearts", by Celeste Ng, the author states, "And suddenly, a door clicks open in Bird's mind. Why his father is always so cautious, why he's always nagging Bird to follow this particular route or that..." In summation, Ethan advises Bird to lay low and not cause any trouble as to protect himself from any possibility of harm.

Does Ethan's (Bird's father) advice to Bird about staying invisible and not putting himself in scenarios where he draws attention to himself, such as not putting up anti-PACT posters with Sadie, actually keep Bird safe from acts of violence and improve opinions of Asians in the general public or does it just allow the system of discrimination increasingly embedded into society? This relates back to the topic of conformity and how systems of oppression coerces groups experiencing discrimination to align with some sort of expected ideology or character. Additionally, this can be tied back to the events of 9/11 and how Muslims and Arabs were heavily discriminated against and felt there was no safe space to speak out against Islamophobia.

Fawwaz:

Throughout *Our Missing Hearts*, Celeste Ng presents art and storytelling as the primary vehicles of resistance against PACT's censorship. Margaret's underground broadcasts draw on historical models of cultural preservation, including the example of Anna Akhmatova, whose poems were memorized and destroyed in order to survive Soviet censorship. By the novel's end, Bird comes to understand his mother's survival through collective memory: "Somewhere out there are people who still know her poems, who've hidden scraps of them away in the fold of their minds before setting match to the papers in their hands" (Ng 324). Similarly, anonymous public art installations such as yarn webs, ice sculptures and bottle caps, circulate the phrase "our missing hearts" in ways the state cannot fully suppress.

How does Ng portray storytelling, language, and collective memory as forms of resistance against cultural erasure? How do Ng and Zitkala Sa each depict the pressures placed on language and cultural identity, and what role do storytelling and memory play in responding to those pressures? How might these ideas connect back to Richard Henry Pratt's philosophy of "Americanization" and his belief that indigenous children should be separated from their culture?

At the same time, *Our Missing Hearts* emphasizes the costs and limitations of resistance: Margaret is captured, Marie Johnson is killed, and Bird's father goes into prolonged silence. To what extent does the novel portray storytelling and collective memory as effective forms of politics? Does the ending suggest that preserving culture is enough to challenge oppressive systems, or does Ng leave the larger political struggle unresolved?

Eva:

In *Our Missing Hearts*, Ng describes how many approached PACT when it was first enacted. She states, "PACT, its proponents insisted, would strengthen and unify the nation. Left unsaid was that unity required a common enemy. One box in which to collect all their anger." (pg 186) This common enemy made many individuals stay silent because they believed the act would not affect them. During the Civil Rights movements protesters were often met with violence so many US Citizens were wary of joining in. In his letter from Birmingham Jail Martin Luther King Junior states "Injustice anywhere is a threat to justice everywhere... Whatever affects one directly, affects all indirectly."

In the book, PACT is often dismissed by US Citizens. The text says, "They shield away from discussing PACT at all, afraid they might be next...The calculation everyone made before parting their lips, before setting fingers to keys: how important was it to say?" (pg 228) How did staying silent about PACT's discrimination towards Asian American families ultimately threaten the justice of all US Citizens? In what ways does staying silent cause a greater threat to American citizens than speaking up?

Emilie

1. A major theme in American Studies is the importance of stories. During the Jim Crow era of the South, Emmett Till was beaten to death and dumped in a river because a woman lied about him whistling at her. His mother chose to tell his story by having an open casket funeral with his body laid out as it had been found, stating, "I think everybody needed to know what happened to Emmet Till." In *Opal Viola Victoria Bear Shield*, Opal's mother says "...the world is made up of stories, just stories, and stories about stories" (58). Finally, in *Our Missing Hearts*, Ng writes, "And how much difference can it really make, just one story, even all these stories taken together and funneled into the ear of a busy world..." (299). **What role do stories play in exercising justice in our society and how are they(stories) used to change a person's perspective?**